

A close-up photograph of a star-nosed mole (Condalia maritima) in its natural habitat. The mole's head is visible on the left, with its long, pinkish, star-shaped tentacles extended towards the center. The background is filled with dense green foliage, including various leaves and ferns. The lighting is natural, highlighting the texture of the mole's skin and the vibrant green of the plants.

Star performer

The star-nosed mole of North America is a hunter with an incredibly good sense of touch. It can barely see, but it can feel the tiniest soil animals using a ring of 22 fleshy tentacles around its nostrils. With a total of 25,000 tiny touch sensors, the tentacles are more sensitive than human fingertips, and they constantly wriggle, testing the soil for food. If a tentacle touches something promising, the mole quickly feels it with the lowest pair, which are the most sensitive of all. It can identify food and swallow it in just 0.25 seconds, making it one of the fastest-eating mammals in the world.